

File MS-12

To: (unknown), INTERNET:webmaster@cseti.org
From: "A.J. Craddock", INTERNET:webmaster@cseti.org
Date: 10/20/98, 5:18 PM
Re: Star Wars Redux - Memory Lane

Sender: webmaster@cseti.org
Received: from acme.sb.west.net (acme.sb.west.net [205.254.224.2])
by arl-img-1.compuserve.com (8.8.6/8.8.6/2.14) with ESMTTP id RAA10189;
Tue, 20 Oct 1998 17:18:20 -0400 (EDT)
Received: from test.cseti.org (sba-cal-04.ix.netcom.com [204.32.201.36])
by acme.sb.west.net (8.9.0.Beta5/8.9.0.Beta5) with SMTP id OAA27710;
Tue, 20 Oct 1998 14:07:06 -0700 (PDT)
Message-Id: <3.0.3.32.19981020140706.00fef3e4@west.net>
X-Sender: craddock@west.net
X-Mailer: QUALCOMM Windows Eudora Pro Version 3.0.3 (32)
Date: Tue, 20 Oct 1998 14:07:06 -0700
To: webmaster@cseti.org
From: "A.J. Craddock" <webmaster@cseti.org>
Subject: Star Wars Redux - Memory Lane
Mime-Version: 1.0
Content-Type: text/plain; charset="us-ascii"

From the June 1992 Bulletin of the Atomic Scientists:

No party for Star Wars

The Strategic Defense Initiative (SDI) celebrated its ninth anniversary in March (1992), at about the same time that "Star Wars" costs passed the \$30 billion mark - making it by far the most expensive military project in history.

The March 31 Defense Media Review, a publication of the Center for Defense Journalism, complained that after nine years the press still cannot figure SDI out; with the exception of Newsweek, the Review continued, the media marked the event "with little more than a whimper."

Newsweek (March 23) did review the record, noting that as the program's X-ray laser, neutral- and charged-particle beams, and electromagnetic rail guns each failed to work out as their proponents claimed, SDI "evolved" into a less ambitious but no less costly program. Or as Elliott Kennel, a former air force nuclear engineer, put it, by 1987 he and many of his colleagues at SDI "realized that the game was over."

Anniversary coverage was more of a roast than a celebration. Kosta Tsipis, director of MIT's Program in Science and Technology for International Security, described SDI simply: "It's a fraud." And Richard Garwin, a weapons consultant who has advised every administration since Eisenhower's, reiterated his belief that SDI's goals were technologically "impossible to accomplish" (Philadelphia Inquirer, March 22, 1992).

The Star Warriors were also busy fending off charges by whistleblower Aldric Saucier, an SDI analyst who accused SDI officials of falsifying data, redirecting money Congress allocated for one program to others, and underestimating various costs from between \$222 billion and \$1 trillion. Saucier also said that SDI hid or destroyed hundreds of scientific reports that found flaws in its systems. SDI officials had sacked Saucier, and dismissed his charges with dark hints about his sanity. Then in April, an independent inquiry led to Saucier's reinstatement. But the Pentagon soon suspended him, this time claiming that he had made misleading statements on his Defense Department job application- 23 years ago.

The General Accounting Office (GAO) marked SDI's anniversary with two reports critical of "Brilliant Pebbles," SDI's plan to litter near-space

with 8,000 orbiting interceptors. In February, GAO complained that SDI has changed direction "several different times, consuming billions of dollars along the way," and questioned the wisdom of the Defense Department's costly decision to integrate the space-based Pebbles system with a separate ground-based system authorized by Congress. In March, GAO struck again, warning Congress that SDI's computer animations "do not demonstrate that Brilliant Pebbles can be built and will work." GAO also cautioned against judging current computer simulations that "test" interceptors with unknown or unproven characteristics. As GAO put it, the "design features of the interceptor were too dynamic" for any conclusions about how and whether the system will work.

This year's SDI budget is \$4 billion. One senior SDI intelligence official told the Philadelphia Inquirer that the only reason SDI goes on is the feast it provides for contractors. He described SDI officials as check writers awash with so much money that "they depend on their contractor friends to tell them what to do." And SDI will not feel the sting of cuts in the Defense budget; Congress has tentatively approved the \$5.4 billion the Bush administration requested for next year.

-Linda Rothstein

Star Wars is, of course, alive and well in 1998.

Regards

Tony Craddock
Web Administrator
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<http://www.cseti.org>